

screen. Once the compilation is complete, one should be able to see the message 'successful' as the last line in the compile log.

5. Connect button. The connect button above the editor window allows one to virtually connect to the gpasm simulator so as to start the simulation of the program. This button is to be pressed only after the compilation is successful.

6. Run. Once the simulation is over, press the run button available at the top to see the output of the simulation.

What do the users have to say

Although we can see some benefits of using Piklab, the actual users have mixed reviews about it. The communities such as edaboard.com, Bit Bang Theory and ReviewStream have the following users' perspective:

1. "I have personally used Piklab to program 16f628a and 16f88 devices, writing the code in ASM and programming them with a JDM serial programmer and haven't faced any problem ever. I find Piklab very easy to use and it is really a very powerful tool. It does not support MPLAB's directives so, if you have previously written any code on MPLAB using directives, you need to remove them and change them for standard mpasm code to be able to

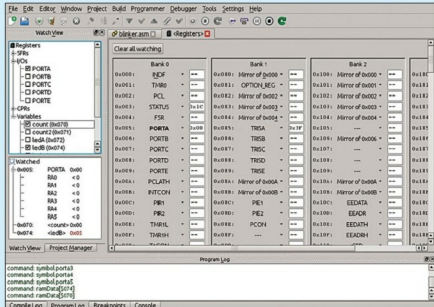


Fig. 4: Register view

Quick steps to build a project using Piklab

1. Start a project
2. Add sourcefile(s) to this project
3. Select the toolchain, processor and programmer
4. Press on the Build Project button. A hex file will be created
5. Connect the programmer by pressing on the Connect button
6. Insert a PIC microcontroller into your programmer
7. Press on buttons: Erase, Blank Check and Program
8. Press on the Verify button to check, if the hex file was written without errors into the PIC

compile that code on Piklab."

2. "That's the best IDE available for programming microcontroller. It can be used to write code, compile it,

test it using simulation and debugging tools and even programming the actual microcontroller."

3. "Piklab does not always work with the Tiny Bootloader. I had it working when I used Ubuntu 11.04 Natty Narwhal and some version of Piklab that I cannot remember now. But since I upgraded to Oneiric Ocelot and a new version of Piklab, the Tiny Bootloader programming interface stopped working. However, there is another easy way to use Tiny Bootloader with Piklab, which involves installing Tinybldlin, the Linux interface for the Tiny PIC bootloader."

4. "I love Piklab! It is the best solution to program and debug PIC microcontroller under Linux, but it still has some road to go before it can reach Microchip's MPLAB IDE." ●

The author is a technical journalist at EFY. The article is based on the Piklab document available at Sourceforge.net

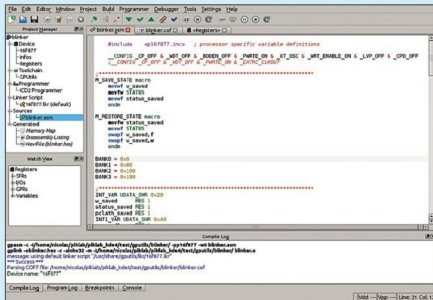


Fig. 5: Source code editor